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Resonance and Joy: A Pedagogical Relationship

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Abstract

The world we currently experience is characterized by acceleration and change. Western ideals of individualistic success, along with surrounding social structures, leads to alienation (Rosa, 2019). The purpose of education is to prepare students for the world they will encounter, but what world? We argue that rather than preparing students for a disconnected world focused on the individual, instead we aim for students to contribute to a changing future with a foundation of resilience, belonging, and connection. Hartmut Rosa (2019) has proposed the concept of resonance as a counterpoint to alienation – as an alert and present willingness to enter dialogue with the world. This view of presence has relevance to pedagogy through joy: joy becomes essential for resilience in an alienating age. This essay explores how Rosa's concept of resonance can provide a conceptual architecture for a joy-centred pedagogy. Drawing on Ross Gay's work on joy and its interaction with Rosa, we suggest that resonant pedagogical encounters create a reciprocal relationship with joy: an emergent quality of relational, dialogical, and meaningful engagements. We argue that resonance-oriented learning environments can foster the capacities students need for an uncertain future by developing attitudes, relational sensitivity, curiosity, and agency.

The way the universe sat waiting to become,
quietly, in the nether of space and time (Gay, 2008, p.28).

The purpose of education is to prepare students for the world they will encounter, but what world? Is it the one we careen towards beyond our wanting and doing, or the one we wish to create? The world as currently experienced is often characterized by rapid change and what Hartmut Rosa (2019) calls acceleration. Particularly in Western contexts, society promotes a strong focus on the individual, and Rosa (2019) argues that the Western ideal of individualistic progress and success,

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along with the surrounding social structures, leads to alienation: from ourselves, from others, and from the world. He writes that we live in a structural context that is "geared towards continuous progress by means of growth, acceleration, and innovation" (p. 21), with competition as a key feature. This concept of everyday life results in a lack of authentic experiences and encounters with our surroundings that, if engaged with, could strengthen our sense of connection. We argue that rather than preparing students for a disconnected world focused on the individual, we aim for them to contribute to a changing future with a foundation of resilience and belonging.

In this context, Rosa (2019) has articulated the concept of *resonance* as the counterpoint and antidote to alienation. Resonance, as described by Rosa, is an alert and present willingness to enter into dialogue with ourselves and the world; in the encounter with others, with subject matter and mastery, with aspects of our experience with nature, art, culture, or spirituality (Rosa, 2019). He suggests that happiness is "the result of a relationship to the world defined by the establishment and maintenance of stable *axes of resonance* that allow subjects to feel themselves sustained or even secured in a responsive, accommodating world" (p. 30). Indeed, he sees the current environmental crisis and crisis of democracy as the collapse of the axes of resonance (p. 42). We connect this broader theory of resonance to the experience of joy and undertake here a conceptual inquiry into the nature of the relationship between them.

Poet and author Ross Gay (2024), in his book *Inciting Joy,* explores a series of what he calls "incitements," writing of deeply simple yet profound experiences - the often unnotable, unnoticed elements of experience that we take for granted. For example, in "The Third Incitement: The Garden," Ross describes the anticipation of ordering seeds during the winter — "Let it be said: there is no greater sucker for seeds than me. I am batty, I am seduced" (p. 29). He writes of the personal connections evoked by his garden as he walks through it in summer - this plant or that, given by people who have important roles in his life: "Bryce gave us the black raspberries under the crab apple tree. The figs and the gogi back by the garage come from my friend Jay's father, Mr. Lau… Jessica gave us the daffodils. My friend Ada sent some sweetgrass…" (p. 30). This kind of presence and awareness of connection, according to Gay, is an approach to experiencing joy. As Gay (2019) argues, "The garden makes you grab the nearest thing so you can keep crawling through it. It might be that logics of delight interrupt the logics of capitalism" (p. 30). This view of presence has clear transferable value to pedagogy through joy: the concrete particulars of joy become essential for resilience in a cold and alienating age, become a means of resistance.

Rosa too, through the lens of resonance, explores how such encounters can frame us, transform us, and enable us to respond. We suggest that resonant pedagogical encounters are not simply pleasant moments, but rather generative conditions for joy, an emergent quality of relational, dialogical, and meaningful engagements that counteract alienation. These concepts receive support from traditions of *Bildung* and *formation*, which describe how individuals develop through active engagement with both the physical and cultural world (Solberg & Hansen, 2015). The relational element is key: schools and educational contexts offer a sense of togetherness where students have the chance to experience community and to experience and take part in something greater than themselves (Lea, 2024). This togetherness promotes belonging, which is regarded as a core part of what makes us human and contributes to a person's flourishing, well-being and their *Bildung* (cultivation) (Lea, 2024). In contrast, a lack of belonging may lead to loneliness, or in Rosa's terms, alienation from the world. We argue that resonance-oriented learning environments can foster the capacities students need to face an uncertain future by developing relational sensitivity, belonging, curiosity, and agency. At the same time, resonant experiences are not synonymous with harmony, as Rosa reminds us; rather, they can accommodate unease, friction, and uncertainty. They awaken us and make us responsive. In this space, joy often arises, not as an

escape from what is being demanded of us, but as movement and response in the encounter with the world (Gay, 2019). Resonance creates a conceptual architecture within which joy can flourish.

Taking as our point of departure the ideas of Hartmut Rosa and Ross Gay, this conceptual work explores how resonance and joy operate as reciprocal processes to underpin a joy-centred pedagogy. We bring Rosa's theoretical critique of acceleration and efficiency—specifically from *Resonance: A Sociology of Our Relationship to the World* (2019)—into conversation with Gay's embodied and poetic insights on collective joy, particularly in *Inciting Joy* (2024). To ground these theoretical perspectives in higher education, we draw on Scipio et al.'s (2026) recent work on joy-centred pedagogy in STEM and integrate insights from the Nordic *Bildung* tradition. Ultimately, we propose that placing Rosa's conceptual model of resonance in dialogue with Gay's vibrant lens on joy offers a novel contribution to educational discourse, providing a vital framework for inclusion, sustainable engagement, creative agency, and well-being for both students and educators.

Rosa's Theory of Resonance

Rosa (2019) argues that "the quality of a human life (and of social conditions) cannot be measured simply according to available options and resources, but rather requires examining the relationship to the world…." (p. 26), and as introduced above, he describes this relationship as *resonance*. Rosa articulates resonance along three axes: the horizontal, diagonal, and the vertical. The horizontal axis expresses our relationships with others: family, friends, and also more broadly in the political sphere, with the enactment of democracy as a key concept. The diagonal axis is the way we relate to objects that have meaning; for example, the tools of a craftsperson hold resonance for that person in relation to their work. It is also, more broadly, the world of work and of sport, and of particular interest to this present writing, the world of education and schooling. Finally, the vertical axis is the most abstract: this is the promise of religion and spirituality, the voice of nature, the power of art, and the mantle of history. For the purposes of this essay, we focus on a specific aspect of the diagonal axis - the resonance possible in the world of education and schooling. However, the other axes do indeed come into play within the classroom as well and surround it - through the relationship students have with their families, through related activities such as sport, through the curriculum (for example, the power of art and the mantle of history).

Western perspectives on our relationship with the world have historically created a division between the human world and what it sees to be the inanimate world of objects, even extending this to the living world of nature. This view has had considerable consequence, as Rosa (2019) writes:

> The twenty-first century, however, has given rise to a growing number of voices who acknowledge the strict division between a living, speaking, animated human world of culture and a mute natural world of raw material to be dominated and controlled not simply as a cognitive precondition for the rise of scientific or technological mastery of the world, but also as a perspective that reduces the number of different possible ways of relating to the world and to nature and thus may constitute a potential cause of our current ecological crisis. (p. 227)

In this light, the stakes are very high. Critical to the theory of resonance, and to the present argument about the potential for joy-centred pedagogy to interact dynamically with that resonance, is the idea that "we understand resonant relationships to objects not simply as exceptional poetic forms of experience *apart from the real world*. . . but rather as *everyday* modes of relation, i.e. as

ways of relating to the world through things that are also possible in everyday life" (Rosa, 2019, p. 230). This is salient to the experience of education - joy and resonance become possible in the most normal, everyday setting of the classroom. And as seen above, in creating this possibility we also create hope for the world.

A key aspect of resonance is the idea of a relational attunement - that we not only respond to someone or something in the world, but also that it responds to us in a reciprocal relationship. This experience can often produce a feeling of joy - the joy of mastering a new concept, for example, or when a musical instrument responds to our touch. Here then, we begin to glimpse the reciprocal relationship between resonance and joy. The concept of attunement becomes critical in the context of schooling. Rosa argues that current pedagogy, which often conceptualizes the teacher as more of a guide or facilitator, misses the crucial role teachers play in creating resonant possibilities for students. Rosa uses the metaphor of teachers as a "tuning fork" - teachers should not be didactic or rigid in the classroom, but neither should they abandon students to pursue their resonant relationships to the world alone. He notes that, "the notion that education is about teachers *making the world resound* for their students is ever-present in the tradition of pedagogical thought" (p. 243). Interestingly, he suggests that the curriculum plays a subordinate, rather than central, role in this process. Instead, Rosa argues that "our relationship to the world rather is developed through close interactions with people and things involving processes of recognition and distinction" (p. 238). This recalls Ted Aoki's (1986/1995/2005) suggestion that education is not located in the teacher, the students, or the curriculum (either as planned or as lived), but dwells in the spaces between them.

Rosa points specifically to the time of adolescence, a sensitive time where we establish resonant relationships to particular activities:

> We discover in the process that some things speak to us, while others do not…. Axes of resonance can only be established when we discover that we can be good at a certain activity or in a certain subject, that we can achieve or move something, that the material (the violin, the baseball, a poem, a party platform, a neutron star) "responds" to us. (p. 239)

In this way, during adolescence, school becomes a critical actor in the lives of young people - where they can become tuned in to elements of the world and establish resonance, or become particularly vulnerable to the experience of alienation. Rosa writes, "Education in the sense of resonance theory, however, is aimed not at cultivating either the world or the self, but rather at *cultivating relationships to the world*" (p. 241).

Critically, Rosa notes extensive research on class disparity in education, suggesting that middle-class students have access to the potential for resonant educational experiences while lower-class students are presented with a rigid version of the world, which then reproduces class structures through a lack of opportunities and encouragement to develop resonance. For example, more than four decades ago, Jean Anyon (1981) demonstrated just such a process in her landmark study about the implementation of social studies curriculum across schools in the same geographic location, but different socio-economic communities. She writes, "By situating school knowledge in its particular social location, we can see how it may contribute to contradictory social processes of conservation and transformation. We see the schools reproducing the tensions and conflicts of the larger society" (p. 38). Rosa gives us one means through which this divergence occurs, through differential access to opportunities for resonance. He writes of his extensive experience with "gifted and talented" students and suggests that what distinguishes these students is not intelligence, but rather their innate or learned capacity for resonance. He argues that all students

need access to teachers who will intentionally cultivate students' possibilities for resonance and model their own passionate resonance with the subject matter. This then becomes a joyful pedagogy, which makes space for presence, mindful noticing, slowing down, inquiry, mastery, and connection - rather than a focus on externally determined outcomes or assessments. Of course, the external drivers do not disappear, so the task is a complex one for the teacher - how to meet external demands while at the same time creating a container in the classroom where resonance and joy become possible. At times, this becomes an act of resistance, and admittedly this may be more or less possible for individuals depending on their stage of career and social location. Therefore, it becomes incumbent on those in positions of more power, and the system itself, to create spaces for resonance and joy, recognizing the impact of relentless measurement and evaluation at the level of the classroom and to work against it.

Understanding and Inciting Joy

Gay (2024) asks, "what does joy incite?" and answers his own question this way: "My hunch is that joy is an ember for or precursor to wild and unpredictable and transgressive and unboundaried solidarity. And that solidarity might incite further joy. Which might incite further solidarity" (p. 9). Joy then becomes a forum for both agency and community. Gay argues that we are united in our experiences of not only joy but sorrow - not the same sorrows, necessarily, but the deeply human experience of it - and "adamantly" advocates that we recognize sorrow as a necessary ingredient to joy, that "rather than warring with sorrow, we lay down our swords and invite sorrow in" (p. 4). In a section entitled "Dispatch from the Ruins (School: The Eleventh Incitement)," Gay outlines the existential angst so many educators experience - the strange dissonance between our passions for the subject matter we teach (in Rosa's terms, the resonance) as well as sincere love for students, and the expectations of the institution. Our education system ever shifts toward a more instrumental, standardized, and market-oriented approach. Such practices value efficiency and marketing models, which undermine the slow processes important for learning. Gay argues,

> Sometimes the ruins look just like this.
>
> And obscuring that *this* is a ruins, concealing it, pretending it is otherwise, is one of the main objectives, it seems to me, of the U. The objective is to make our lives as the ruins invisible to ourselves, in no small part by pretending that what is ruinous is, in fact, a good, and enlisting us in this project, not only as practitioners and believers, but as missionaries. (p. 146)

For those of us working in teaching and learning centres within universities, we feel this missionary expectation all the more fully, as we preach, for example, the doctrine of learning outcomes, even as we know that, as Gay says, "real learning is unpredictable, improvisatory, and by definition, confounding" (p. 147). For many, this creates a sense of cognitive dissonance in our work.

So then, what is the alternative? Gay instead lists a series of invitations and provocations he provides to his students that are playful, disruptive, impossible, and meant to open up their thinking and possibilities rather than foreclose them. For example: "write 30 plays in 60 minutes… make an atlas of glee/sorrow/forgetfulness… [a]puppet opera… impossible screenplays… invent and build instruments" (pp. 164-5). He advocates "making beautiful shit together" (p. 152). He is bullheaded on the problem of evaluation, suggesting that instead we be "wonderstruck, flummoxed with delight, and calling attention to what was unpredictably beautiful" (p. 166). As educators in

the system, we too wonder how this could possibly work, how we could take such an approach and keep our jobs. But what if it is possible?

— pause —

We may then reasonably think that if it were possible, it might only be so in the depths of a creative writing department, where Gay resides. And yet, in a recent article, Scipio et al. (2026) suggest a pedagogy of joy in the context of STEM and STEAM education, towards a "more equitable and responsive learning" (p. 313). This work resonates with Gay (and indeed they draw on his work as well as others). Of joy, they write:

> Joy is a complex expression of a core human experience. You can feel it in your bones. Many authors have explored happiness but we see joy as something different, deeper, and more about entanglements with one another (Cruz, 2023; hooks 2018; Lorde 1984, 2007). We define our joy in opposition to a toxic positivity that requires people to smile in the midst of their struggle. Our joy, rather, rejects the idea that a people can be reduced to a single emotion or narrative; our joy is about complex and nuanced entanglements through the things that connect us, and about music, breath, movement, and laughter. Our joy exists in relationship to each other, communities, power, privilege, and oppression. Our joy exists in relationship with our fear and pain. Our joy is resistance. (p. 314)

These entanglements can also be viewed as facets of Rosa's concept of relational attunement, which informs how we respond to the world around us in reciprocal and resonant ways. Note the echoing of both Rosa and Gay in the observation that 'joy' may not always mean 'happiness' - that joy is a complex experience encompassing difficult emotions and experiences. Scipio et al. (2026) above see joy as also existing in relation to fear and pain, while Rosa (2019) points out that resonance need not be only about a feeling of harmony; it can include unease as well. Recall Gay's claim that sorrow must always accompany joy. Both can therefore be seen as part of our complexity, lingering between our fears and feelings of unease, and where we seek to move ourselves towards joy and away from fear, where we seek resonance and connection with others and the world.

In Practice, or the Poetics of What Now?

What ways can this be enacted? Remember Rosa's image of the teacher who helps students access the world, and poetry can be one way of accessing resonance of the body and the world. Mary Oliver is one poet who has explored this relationship intensively, and what we might see as joyful entanglements. In her well-known poem *Wild Geese* she writes, "Whoever you are, no matter how lonely / the world offers itself to your imagination," creating a sense of belonging in the "soft animal of your body," listening to the geese above, "high in the clean blue air."

Gay writes of the power of poetry itself:

> Poetry might make nothing happen.
>
> Inside of which anything can happen, maybe most dangerously, our actual fealties, our actual devotions and obligations, which is to the most rambunctious, mongrel, inconceivable assemblage of each other we could imagine.

> You ever been on a dance floor like that? Ever on a basketball court like that? Ever in the long sweaty collaborative dream of an orchard like that? Ever in a study group like that? A potluck? Ever a forest? Ever a garden? Ever a conversation? A classroom? Ever an impromptu rendition of Shai's "If I Ever Fall in Love"? Ever a Hula Hoop gang? Ever when making applesauce from the apples from your beloved neighbor's tree? Ever when trying to get the steps from the video of New Edition's "If It Isn't Love"? Ever on your roller skates? Your skateboard? Ever making love? Ever at a laying on of hands? Ever in a dream? (2024, p.55)

Gay evokes our experiences at their most intense and poetic, where we experience flow. How do we create a holistic pedagogy, one that is attuned, entangled, relational, resonant, joyful? As we write, we know that there is no simple "how-to" guide here. Indeed, the desire for instrumentality in operationalizing this or that pedagogy works against the nature of joy and resonance. For Rosa, the role of the teacher is to model and create an environment where resonance can occur, as discussed above, and act as a tuning fork for resonance, helping students to hear their own vibrating connections to the world - to topics, to skills, to others, to learning. He aims, ultimately, for the adaptive transformation of the world. Scipio et al. (2026) are explicit in their desire — "we seek to have educators develop POY [Pedagogies of Joy] to transform the ways in which they work with students that affirm dignity, foreground full sensemaking repertoires, and prioritize transformative teaching practices" (p. 315). They outline four distinct pedagogical approaches:

1. **Attending to affective entanglements:** "by seeking to know the learners within their contexts, deepening knowledge of what brings them joy, and sharing in joyful moments" (p. 315).
2. **Switching roles:** "Switching roles asks that those traditionally positioned with less power within oppressive systems (e.g., children/youth/students) are offered opportunities for leadership" (p.316).
3. **Cultivating third space:** "spaces of hybridity that are collaboratively created by teachers/students, adults/youth/children, facilitators/educators/learners in ways that recognize as valuable and draw on multiple cultural repertoires and disciplinary knowledge and practice" (p. 316).
4. **(Co)Dream to enact:** "Following children/youth/students as intellectual leaders allows us to collaboratively dream of and chart futurities and pathways through learning environments that are more just, equitable, and joyful" (p. 316).

Striking in these pedagogies is the disruption of traditional power narratives within educative structures, as though the cultivation of joy requires an emancipatory stance, where joy emerges through freedom. This means rethinking boundaries and limits, and allowing for play together in relational activities that affirm dignity, sustaining relational collaborative learning. Gay (2024), who describes himself as becoming "an unwitting deputy in this unit-making machine" (p. 155), tells a story about a professor giving all students A`s in the beginning of the semester so the students didn't have the worry of being "good, right, or approved of," but could rather discover something unexpected and even "get beautifully lost" (p.154), underscoring the value of looking for beauty and joy in our pedagogical practices. In these teaching and learning processes, we might cultivate a space where we allow our lived experiences to intersect with disciplinary knowledge,

"welcoming whole people and their entire lived experience within our learning spaces. Joy should not be dismissed as frivolous or a threat to learning (Ryoo, 2019)" (Scipio et al., 2026, p. 327).

These pedagogies call to mind for us the early childhood education approaches of the Reggio Emilia Schools in Italy, where inquiry, artistic expression, democratic processes, and joyful surprises are woven into the fabric of the schools (Edwards et al., 1998). Indeed, as Loris Malaguzzi, one of the founders of the schools famously exhorted, "*niente senza gioia"* [nothing without joy].

It might also look like the simple practice of writing letters. In previous work, the authors wrote long-form letters to one another about the transformative potential of hermeneutics and Scholarship of Teaching and Learning, and we now recognize that these letters also afforded a basis for the resonance of a developing friendship, and over time, resonances of art and nature (Yeo & Stalheim, 2024). Furthermore, we have been experimenting with letter writing as a pedagogy and method for inquiry in our teacher education courses. We each have used letter writing in our contexts to amplify students' voices in teaching and learning, valuing its slower pace as a counter to the acceleration and alienation of modern life (Rosa, 2022), and to explore what we do not see or measure in education. The letters invited personal reflection on meaning, identity, and values, while creating space to explore new insights emerging from students' stories, allowing students to express their experiences and reflections during lessons, and possibly get a glimpse of resonant revelations from the students. What we found was that letters and personal narratives can create a space for thinking and writing that allows one to be touched by something or someone, fostering resonance and dialogue with oneself, others, and the world (Løfblad et al., 2025).

Or it might look like a walk beside the ocean, as Stephen J. Smith (1992) describes in "Physically Remembering Childhood," where he explores the difference the presence of children makes, specifically, how re-experiencing a place he explored with his own children transformed the experience for both them and himself. This writing reveals deep resonance of family and nature, a joyful pedagogy in the third space of a family walk; it reveals entanglement and an embodied experience of the world. Smith writes:

> I want to understand how a very physical sense of engagement in the present is not just an event to be recalled, but an experience through which the past resonates in physically palpable ways. In particular I want to understand the significance in such experience of being with children and how the presence of children makes such experience profoundly memorable both for them and for me. My hunch is that childhood may be remembered best by being with children and that the most vibrant memories of childhood may be those caught in the immediacy of our present engagement with children. These memories may have as their pedagogic corollary a sympathy for the activity of children and a responsiveness to the course that this activity could most fruitfully take. (p. 86)

In this light, we see both the upending of roles advocated by Scipio — Smith is co-experiencing the world with his children rather than being their guide — and the wisdom he brings with him, and the vision allowed by his vantage point. He is not only creating an experience for the children from which they will inevitably learn: he is transforming his own memory and recasting it in the present. To connect to the world is to continually reconnect. As he writes, "For what makes us most mindful of our bodily connectedness to the world is a feeling of physical continuity between prior experience and present situatedness" (p. 97). This is how resonance is created; this is one means of becoming the tuning fork.

Through our inquiry, we have uncovered a pedagogical relationship and deep compatibility between resonance and joy. We argue that paying attention to our pedagogical practice with the

aim of creating space for both resonance and joy can foster students' flourishing and support being-and-becoming (*Bildung*). While resonance and joy originate from different theoretical traditions and places, they both emphasize interrelated aspects of human experience with the world. Both can be understood as being fundamentally concerned with human flourishing and connectedness in a world characterized by acceleration, change, and even alienation. Each perspective highlights the importance of deep experiences and forms of understanding that nurture community, relationships, togetherness, and meaningful engagement with life and the world itself. Despite their differing points of departure, resonance and joy share key characteristics that align with the aims of *Bildung* and belonging, both of which are central to a broader educational mission that prioritizes relationality over measurement. Future work might further theorize the relationship between resonance and joy, empirically seek evidence of coincidence in the classroom, or assess the impact of resonance- and joy-oriented pedagogies on student learning and flourishing.

We acknowledge that the system we currently live in creates numerous structural barriers to such approaches, and that to follow a pathway of joy and resonance requires not only courage but also contextual, relative authority. Therefore, it is critical that educators act in like-minded communities, rather than as individuals, which only again leads back to a sense of alienation. With the examples provided, we have offered glimpses into what a playful and resonant pedagogy might attempt, along with the incitements provided by Ross Gay, Rosa's tuning fork, and Scipio et al.'s entanglements, role switching, cultivations, and (co)dreaming. These pedagogies seem in opposition to the structures we have come to rely on so definitively in educational institutions. In this historical moment, if we aim for nothing less than transformation, then a courageous attempt at joy may not only be desirable, but necessary.

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